ILO REPORT FOR ASIA-PACIFIC

Women in managerial roles: India ranks near bottom

MISSING W IN THE workforce

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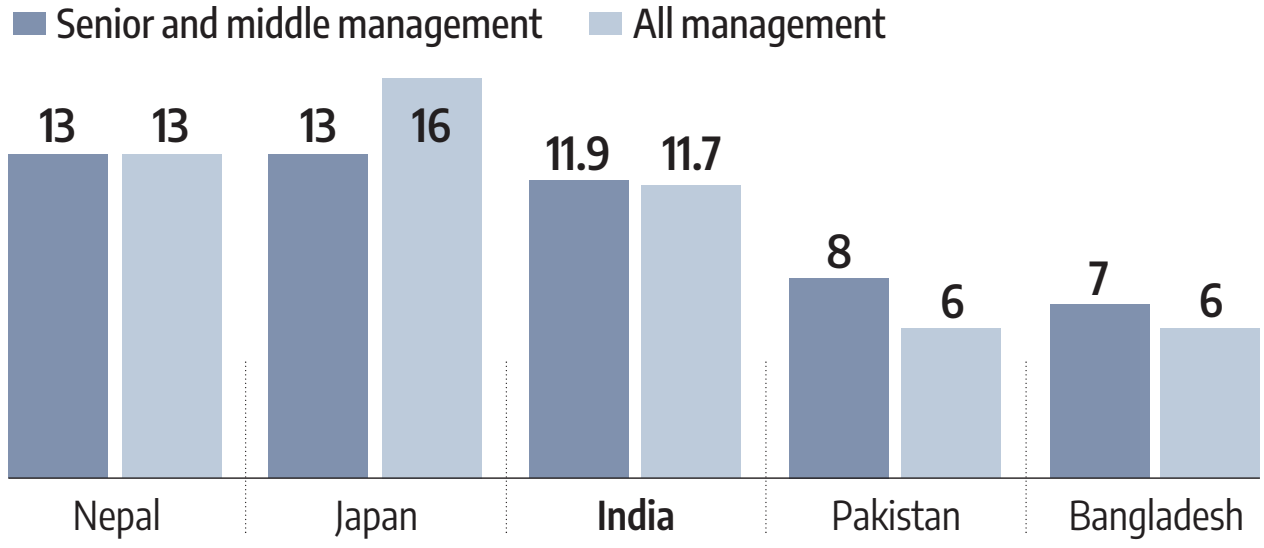
Women hold fewer than 12 per cent of managerial positions in India, placing the country 32nd among 34 economies in the Asia-Pacific region, ahead of only Pakistan and Bangladesh, according to an International Labour Organization (ILO) report released on Tuesday.

The report, titled Women in business and management: Scaling success, also found that women employees in India earn about 28 per cent less per hour than men. This is the fourth-widest gender wage gap among the 23 Asia-Pacific economies covered, after Tonga (about 64 per cent), South Korea (about 41 per cent) and Vanuatu (about 29 per cent). Among managers, however, the gender pay gap in India is close to zero.

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The thickest glass ceilings

Share of women in management positions (in %)



Source: ILO

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Based on 2024 data, the figures cover both management positions as a whole and senior- and middle-management roles, suggesting that women's underrepresentation runs across the managerial hierarchy.

"The gap exists for two major reasons. First, there is a larger stereotyping on what women can or cannot do because of which they may not get considered for managerial positions. Second, household responsibilities force women to withdraw from such positions themselves," said Neetha N, professor at the Centre for Women's Development Studies (CWDS). She said tackling workplace stereotyping would require strong state intervention, including greater representation of women in bureaucratic cadres, particularly at senior levels rather than only at the lower rungs.

At the policy level, Neetha said, stronger institutions for childcare and care work, alongside infrastructure to reduce the burden of household work, would be essential to narrowing the gap. "Even at the corporate level, there should be incentives and policies that enable women to take up these positions," she said. Globally, women earn 78 cents for every dollar earned by men, the report said. Across Asia-Pacific, they account for about one in five managers, against a global share of 30.5 per cent.

"Most of this pay gap cannot be explained by labour market factors such as differences in education levels or working hours, but reflects structural barriers, including occupational segregation, undervaluation of women's work and the impact of care responsibilities on career progression," the report said.

In India, 23.1 per cent of female tertiary graduates had studied science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM), compared with 31.4 per cent of male graduates. These figures measure the proportion of graduates within each gender group who studied STEM, rather than women's share of all STEM graduates.

The report draws on an ILO survey of 11,957 enterprises across 99 countries. It found that 68.5 per cent of respondents said gender-equality and diversity initiatives had improved business outcomes, up 11.1 percentage points from 57.4 per cent in 2018.

Initiatives to promote women in management were associated with improved business outcomes at 68.5 per cent of surveyed enterprises, the report said.

Maternity leave and support measures were rated the most effective initiatives by 74.7 per cent of enterprises, followed by action against violence and harassment (74.1 per cent) and equal-pay measures (70.1 per cent). Yet the share of enterprises implementing gender-equality initiatives fell from 37.4 per cent in 2018 to 26.5 per cent in 2025.

Profits rose at 41.6 per cent of firms reporting better business outcomes, the report said. Of these, 87.4 per cent recorded gains of at least 5 per cent, while 13.4 per cent reported gains exceeding 20 per cent. In Asia and the Pacific, about half of these firms reported profit gains of 10-20 per cent, a higher proportion than in the Americas and Europe.

"Enterprises led by a female CEO (chief executive officer) are 6.4 per cent more likely to report better business outcomes than those led by a male CEO, while enterprises with a female board chair are 17.5 per cent more likely to do so than those with a male board chair," the report said.

Globally, the share of firms with gender-balanced management -- where either gender accounts for 40-60 per cent -- increased at senior and top-management levels between 2013 and 2025. At the same time, it declined by 6.4 percentage points at the middle-management level and 1.4 percentage points at the junior level.

Women remain concentrated in human resources (62.5 per cent) and finance and administration (55.4 per cent), but account for just 19.8 per cent of profit-and-loss roles and 26.3 per cent of research and development positions — functions that often serve as pathways to top leadership.